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South Asia, power has been increasingly flowing not from the barrel of a gun or the jackboot of an autocrat, but from its teeming masses. Just look around. In Myanmar, the Min Aung Hlaing-led military junta, which had sacked the democratically elected government of Aung San Suu Kyi in 2021, today faces a bloody civil war that has seen rebels take control of half its territory. In Sri Lanka, the powerful Rajapaksa brothers, Gotabaya and Mahinda, who as president and prime minister respectively had treated the island nation like a family fiefdom, fled to safety in 2022 after people revolted over high inflation and low incomes. Then, in 2023, the Pakistan army saw the unthinkable come to pass when mobs protesting the arrest of deposed prime minister Imran Khan stormed the Lahore corps commander's house and even attacked the army headquarters in Rawalpindi. And just last week, it was Sheikh Hasina, who, ironically, had just completed a record 20 years as the prime minister of Bangladesh (though not consecutively) and thought she was invincible. She faced the brunt of popular anger when what started as a minor student protest exploded into a full-scale people's insurrection that left Hasina only 45 minutes to board an army chopper and flee to India.

For India, the overnight meltdown of the Hasina regime came as a huge diplomatic and strategic setback. For over a decade and a half, India had placed all its bets on Hasina, ignoring her growing authoritarian streak. And now experts are blaming New Delhi for not defending the guardrails of democracy and warning Hasina against crossing them. The January election, which the Opposition boycotted, saw Hasina win a full majority for a fourth successive term. But it was widely perceived as a deeply flawed exercise that not only undermined the norms of democracy but also Hasina's legitimacy and legacy of economic growth. India's silence on her misdemeanours spoke volumes and tarnished its reputation. The anger against India spilled out on Dhaka's streets after Hasina's ouster, as reports of homes of the minority Hindu community being allegedly targeted and some Hindu temples being desecrated filtered in. Mahfuz Anam, the Dhaka-based editor of *Daily Star* who faced the brunt of Hasina's aversion to a free press as he battled more than 70 cases filed against him by her government, says, "There were many who felt that given the influence India exerted over Sheikh Hasina, New Delhi should have restrained her. Now, it is facing the flak for being complicit. India should stop looking at us through the prism of religion and instead view us through the prism of democracy. Despite the stray incidents of violence, India can rest assured that Bangladesh is not Afghanistan or Pakistan. We are a moderate Muslim majority country with a strong Bengali culture of our own."

Among those who were upset with Hasina making a mockery of democracy was the US, but they deferred to India's judgement that, as prime minister, Hasina had kept the forces of Islamist extremism at bay and weakening her would not only unleash such forces but also encourage the Chinese to make bolder advances into the Bay of Bengal. Ashley Tellis, senior fellow at the Washington DC-based Carnegie Endowment for International Peace, for one, feels there were things India should have done on the margins. "New Delhi followed a policy of supporting Hasina no matter what," he says. "India could have warned her of the risks of intensifying authoritarianism that began to define her government in the past several years. But